SOUTH ASIAN
CLIMATE JUSTICE CAMP 2025

29th to 31st August, 2025



Organized By:

World's Youth for Climate Justice Nepal (WYCJ)

&

Youth Action for Sustainable and Eco Nepal (YASEN)

In Partnership With:

Eco Heart Nepal

Forum for Legal Youths (FLY)

Hoste Hainse

Prakriti Resources Centre (PRC)

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Introduction

The Climate Justice Camp 2025 held from 29th to 31st August at the Annapurna Eco Village, Astham, Pokhara, was a collaborative space that brought youths, activists, community leaders and experts together to discuss urgent issues on climate justice. The three-days immersive program organised by World's Youth for Climate Justice (WYCJ) Nepal and Youth Action for Sustainable and Eco Nepal (YASEN) in partnership with Eco Heart Nepal, Forum for Legal Youths (FLY), Hoste Hainse and Prakriti Resources Centre (PRC) aimed to provide youth participants with adequate knowledge on climate justice and climate regime, International Court of Justice, Advisory Opinion (ICJ-AO), climate finance, loss and damage, policy advocacy and ekota platform.

Program objectives

1. Raise awareness among youth, indigenous groups, and policymakers on climate justice, human rights, and international law through outreach and education.
2. Interactions and networking with the local and diverse people to ensure inclusive, community-led climate solutions.
3. Implement the decision of the ICJ Advisory Opinion on climate change into actionable policy and accountability tools in South Asia.
4. Prepare a declaration paper on the issue of climate change for South Asia via legal training, advocacy and mentorship.

Participants profile

The event was attended by 55 participants, selected from the South Asian Climate Justice fellowship. These participants, aged 18-35, represented South Asian countries, a diverse mix of ethnicities, genders, and identities. Out of the 55 participants, 13 were foreigners and 42 were from Nepal. The country representation was also broad, with participants coming from Nepal, India, Bangladesh, Sri Lanka, Bhutan and Maldives. This diversity created an inclusive and dynamic environment for learning, collaboration, and innovation.

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Opening Session

The "The South Asian Climate Justice Camp" was a three day event that was coordinated and managed by youths under technical and financial assistance from different partners. The opening ceremony was moderated by Mr. Chetan Jethara, the president of Forum for Legal Youths. The opening ceremony proceeded effortlessly, setting an impactful tone for the event, with speeches from several key figures, such as:

- **Joshua Anak Belayan,** Meaningful Youth engagement UNDP, emphasized on challenges faced by south Asian countries due to climate change. He also shared the stories about the campaigns for climate justice that pushed the ICJ to render its advisory opinion. He also highlighted the Ekota Platform which collectively raises the voices of people fighting against climate justice and influences a global climate discussion.
- **Teknath Gautam,** Chair person of Ward. no. 6 of Machhapuchre Municipality was glad to see the active youth engagement and shared hopes for the declaration or any outcomes from the camp to make impacts on environment and climate. He highlighted the statement by Arzu Deuba Rana that Nepal falls under those countries with negligible emissions but have to bear the brunt of climate change and impacts equally.
- **Binaya Parajuli,** UNICEF, regional office for South Asia, made a statement that South Asia is such a region with the greatest power to bring change. She provided information on the green rising campaign by UNICEF. She slightly highlighted on NDC 3.0, the third generation of Nationally Determined Contributions (NDCs).





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- **Dr. Rishi Keshab Bikram Shah,** academician, Hosten Haisein, discussed threats to the basic fundamental rights created by the climate vulnerabilities and the greatest power of interaction among the countries and government which leads to a common voice for the problems of climate vulnerabilities.
- **Min Bahadur Gurung,** Chairperson of municipality of Macchapuchre focused on the essentiality of research to tackle the climate related problems and find the solutions.
- **DilliRaj Bhatta,** Provincial head of Gandaki Province highlighted the transboundary problem and common challenges and requisite of sustainable development. He also highlighted the global issues of rising temperature and calls for action to eliminate the risks.

Technical sessions

Session 1: Understanding Climate Justice in South Asia:



Facilitated by Ms. Rupa Basnet, in her session she defined “climate justice” as equitable responses, collaborative and collective effort and shared strategies to address climate change and demands economic amd social justice. Human Rights treaties does not explicitly define the term but associates climate justice with different human rights.She mentioned fair treatment of communities most affected by climate change, especially women, indigenous groups, and the poor, linked environmental protection with human rights, demanding inclusive policies, cultural respect, and gender-sensitive solutions. She further addressed the objectives of SAARC, SAARC declarations and statements and their failure due to lack of accocuntability and national priorities.

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Session 2: ICJ AO: What it is and why it matters? :

Facilitated by Mr. Prajwol Bikram Rana, the session mentioned the ICJAO campaign, which began with 27 students urging Pacific nations like Vanuatu to seek a UN resolution for climate justice. The ICJ's advisory opinion, though non-binding, added legal weight to global climate obligations and complements the Paris Agreement. ICJ rulings on human rights and climate change obligations reaffirmed that human rights and climate-related treaties apply conjunctively and upheld the right to a clean and healthy environment. ICJ rulings on cross-border climate impacts confirmed customary international law obligation to prevent significant transboundary harm and applied the principle of non-refoulement to climate-displaced individuals. While countries like the U.S. may avoid ICJ jurisdiction, domestic courts and international pressure remained tools for accountability.



Session 3: Youth Advocacy: Campaign Design & Legal Frameworks (Group Work):

Facilitated by Ms. Dikshya Subedi, the session mentioned the champions of youth climate advocacy through YASEN and organized LCOY Nepal 2024, empowering young voices in policy and promoting SMARTIE goals to ensure campaigns are inclusive and impactful, pushing for meaningful, not tokenistic, youth participation in climate. Participants learnt to balance energy, understand emotions through interactive games, and sustain momentum in their advocacy. The workshop ended with turning ideas into execution through a clear, inclusive action plan.

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Session 4: International Court of Justice Advisory Opinion [Virtual Panel Discussion] :

Facilitated by Ms. Joie Choudhary and Ms. Jule Schnakberg, the session mentioned the three climate advisory opinions, ICJAO delivered that states have concrete obligations to address the climate crisis, including duties to protect the environment, human rights, and the rights of future generations. ITLOS on sea issues- emissions of GHGs could be considered pollution of the marine environment, and there needs to be prevention, reduction, and control of such pollution with all necessary measures.



Inter-American Court AO ruled that the standard of due diligence needs to be maintained to counter the human causes of climate change and to protect people under its jurisdiction from climate impacts. All in all, all these two advisory opinions delivered a common point, which is that “states have to do more on climate change, and if they don't, they are held accountable”.

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Ms. Joie talked about the historic shift in framing from the global north to the global south: recognition that it is about the global majority vs major polluters, with a small minority causing immense harm. This helped to decolonize the condition and narrative of climate change. North negotiated itself down at the ICJ; it demonstrated how powerful actors had to defend their responsibilities within an international legal framework. She also addressed the whole process of reframing climate change as climate justice, which moves beyond a purely scientific and technical discourse and highlights the moral, ethical, and justice dimensions at the core of the issue.

Session 5: International and National climate discourse and the state of Climate Justice:

Facilitated by Mr. Rajan Thapa, the session initiated with the context of the evolution of Climate Discourse and climate regime, where the session was more focused on human rights in the climate frameworks, COP 28, and the GST Signals, The ICJ Opinion (2025), Persistent systematic barriers, Accountability pathways, and lastly, calling for action.



Session 6: Final Inputs to the Policy Paper: Youth Voices of South Asia via the Ekota Platform (Group Work):

Facilitated by Ms. Swikriti Timsina and Mr. Hemant Kandel, the Ekota platform connected directly with those youth voices who are vulnerable and marginalized. The channel was created as Youth Conversation, South Asian Climate Justice, comprising 300 participants. There were altogether 13 groups that explored the theme of mental health in climate resilience, bridging glacial risks, from global benchmarks to national action, recent glacier outburst of Nepal, climate finance and economic resilience, climate justice and youth distress migration in South Asia, human development due to Climate induced, coastal eco system, blue carbon eco system, livelihood of marginalized farmers, policy recommendations for advancing climate justice in Nepal and Pakistan and Comparative analysis of food sovereignty in Nepal and Bhutan under Climate Change.

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Session 7: Faith, Ethics, and Social Justice:

Facilitated by Mr. Muhammd Younus, the session emphasized the context of religion, Human Rights v. Climate Justice, Islamic Teachings, Maqasid Al-Sharia and Climate Justice, Consumerism and Climate Change, and Technology and Justice.



Session 8: Unpacking Loss and Damage: How are South Asian Countries championing it? :



Facilitated by Ms. Shreya KC, the session emphasized that Nepal emits less than 1% of global greenhouse gases but faces severe impacts like the Melamchi flood, loss as irreplaceable harms (lives, health, culture) and damage as repairable assets (infrastructure) and stressed that the poorest half of the world suffers most and urged youth to act through political pressure, awareness, and people power.

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Session 9: Youth Engagement in Resolving Climate Change Issues Through Education and Capacity Building:

Facilitated by Ms. Rashmi K.C., the session highlighted her work educating marginalized children, promoting recycling, and planting over 900 trees, while participating in global forums like IUCN and COP28/29.

Ms. Anupama Shahi delivered a performance with the message: "We are not defending nature; we are nature defending ourselves."



Session 10: Experience Sharing Session



Facilitated by Mr. Sagar Poudel, the session discussed IAAS's engagement with COP through YOUNGO, including side event applications and youth statement papers, emphasized linking grassroots projects to advocacy, and highlighted the need for youth-led innovations, noting that climate justice is a complex "wicked problem" requiring diverse perspectives and creative solutions.

Session 11: Panel Discussions with Mentors

Facilitated by Ms. Monisha Chaudhary, where mentors Mr. Anubhav Ghimire, Ms. Gauri Jaiswal, Ms. Hiniduma Liyanage C. Umesha, Mr. Prabin Poudel and Ms. Sneha Bhatta reflected on a rewarding fellowship, emphasizing inclusivity, kindness, and gratitude toward mentees and organizers. They encouraged continuing the campaign, fostering hope, practicing practicality, and supporting one another, using the metaphor: "Make sails out of the boat, learn to swim, and let others work." They also praised mentees for their efforts while acknowledging the challenges they faced.

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Session 12: Existing climate policies and their formulation process in South Asia

Facilitated by Mr. Bimal Regmi, this session highlighted the triple planetary crisis (major issue for South Asia) and its solutions, overview of policy context in south Asia, policy in CC Nepal and South Asia, International collaboration, challenges of current institution, architecture youth engagement and influence using social media, raise concerns and calls for public call for feedback on some of policies.



Session 13: History of Annapurna Eco-village

Facilitated by Ms. Kabita Thapa, an entrepreneur who featured nature, culture and adventure, jungle walk, mountain biking, promote local environment, organic food, Preserve culture and, sustainable tourism business, help community and networking, awareness program, job opportunities for local, encourage young people to go to village and do something back, educate the children, teach skills and help justice for climate.

Session 14: Applications of ICJ AO at the local and national levels

Facilitated by Former Supreme Court Justice Ananda Mohan Bhattarai, the session highlighted young environmental lawyers' accountability by filing strategic cases, using international guidelines like ICJ opinions, monitoring environmental law compliance, raising public awareness, and collaborating with communities and NGOs to address climate and environmental issues effectively.



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Session 15: Just Climate Finance: Who pays and Who profits?

Facilitated by Ms. Shreya KC, the session explained that climate finance is encouraged but not mandatory, often favoring mitigation and coming as loans rather than grants, which burdens developing nations. Historical emitters have greater responsibility, but emerging emitters also share duties. Current challenges include broken promises and misuse, with solutions like the polluter pays principle, solidarity levies, and aviation and shipping taxes.



Field Visit: Understanding Climate Impacts at the Grassroots Level

Facilitated by members of the organizing committee leaders for individual groups, this field visit focused on engagement with local Astham households to understand their perspectives and experiences of climate change. Each group visited two houses and administered a structured questionnaire that explored climate variability in the locality and its impacts on their day-to-day lives, livelihoods, and community practices.





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Closing Session

The "South Asian Climate Justice Camp" was a three-day event that was coordinated and managed by youths under technical and financial assistance from different partners. The closing ceremony was moderated by Mr. Hemant Kandel, a core team member at YASEN and Ms. Swikriti Timsina, co-lead at the WYCJ Nepal front. The closing ceremony proceeded with the presence of several key figures who gave the final, concluding remarks for the camp, such as:

- Mr. Bhesh Bahadur Poudel, Minister of Forest and Environment, Gandaki Province, commended the camp for bringing together young voices from across the region. He reiterated Gandaki Province's commitment to supporting community-driven climate action and pledged to strengthen collaboration between the government and youth movements.





- Mr. Min Bahadur Gurung, President of the Machhapuchhre Rural Municipality, expressed pride and gratitude in the completion of the camp.
- Mr. Ananda Mohan Bhattarai, Former Justice of the Supreme Court of Nepal, highlighted the legal and ethical dimensions of climate justice, stressing that protecting the environment is a constitutional responsibility and a moral duty.
- Mr. Teknath Gautam, Chairman of Ward. No. 6 of Machhapuchre Municipality expressed his gratitude and pride in hosting such a significant regional gathering at the local level.

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Cultural Exchange Night

Alongside the technical discussions on climate change, the camp also hosted a Cultural Exchange Night to celebrate diversity and foster collective bonding. Participants showcased performances that included traditional attire, dances, and songs from different backgrounds. The evening created a vibrant space for sharing and appreciating all the different cultures present there, emphasizing the spirit of unity and collaboration. It highlighted that while climate change is a serious issue, addressing it requires solidarity and a strong sense of community.







Challenges faced during the program:

While the program was largely successful, we still lagged in some circumstances:

1. Time management: We could not work as per the schedule since we had many sessions that needed deeper discussions and attention.
2. Elimination of some sessions: Due to time constraints, the mock SAARC could not be conducted as per the planning.
3. Diverse Participant Backgrounds: Participants had varying levels of knowledge about climate justice, making it challenging to balance accessibility and depth.

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Outcomes

The event successfully achieved the following:

1. Youth participants gained a deeper understanding of climate justice, ICJ Advisory Opinion, climate finance, loss and damage, and policy frameworks at national and international levels.
2. Participants got familiarised with sustainable tourism, organic farming, and local entrepreneurship by residing at Annapurna Eco Village.
3. The Declaration on Climate Justice by South Asian youths was prepared through the Ekota platform and policy-focused sessions.
4. The camp opened a platform for future collaboration among youths across borders.

Conclusion

The South Asian Climate Justice camp, 2025, played a pivotal role in directly connecting with youth voices and fostering cross-border solidarity in South Asia. Over the three days, the participants engaged in the discussion of climate justice and climate regime, International Court of Justice, Advisory Opinion (ICJ-AO), climate finance, loss and damage, sustainable practices, climate and policy advocacy, capacity building, and the Ekota platform. Despite minor challenges in time management and the session's adjustments, the camp still served its core objectives. Lastly, the camp has been successful with strong commitments toward policy advocacy, community engagement, and regional cooperation.

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Media Coverage

At Nepal Climate Camp, Pakistani Scholar Calls for Faith-Based Path to Environmental Justice: Pakistani scholar Mr. Muhammad Younus emphasized that faith, alongside science and policy, is essential for advancing climate justice. He highlighted Islamic principles of justice, balance, and stewardship as ethical foundations to drive climate action.

जलवायु परिवर्तनबाट नेपालजस्ता विकासोन्मुख मुलुक बढी प्रभावित: प्रदेश प्रमुख भट्ट: Gandaki Province Head Mr. Dilli Raj Bhatta stressed the urgency of mitigation, sustainable development, and youth engagement for regional climate justice. He stated that developing countries like Nepal are disproportionately affected by climate change.

What should be the role of youth in climate change? Do you have any ideas?
The organizers and participants from different backgrounds provide valuable insights on the objectives of the camp, the learnings, and what they expect from it.

जलवायु न्यायमा आइसिजेको सकारात्मक राय: The International Court of Justice (ICJ) has issued an advisory opinion on climate justice, recognizing arguments advanced by Nepal and other nations. Former Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' was praised for his leadership in presenting Nepal's case.

Pokhara to host South Asian Climate Justice Camp 2025: Pokhara is set to host the South Asian Climate Justice Camp 2025, a three-day youth-led gathering where regional fellows, mentors, and experts will turn global climate frameworks, like the ICJ Advisory Opinion, into community-driven solutions.

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